

cover story NAXALITES

had once described as "infantile disorder," practices annihilation of the enemy. Halbi-speaking boatmen with bows and arrows on their shoulders sit idle as there are few passengers. Forest officials often cross the river, reluctantly, as they fear for their lives, as do other government intruders. Security forces reach Abujmarh only for an ambush while private trusts manage government-aided schools. Gonds, Abuj Marias, Halbaas among other tribes live inside the dense jungles spread across vast expanses of earth rich in mineral deposits. Close to 27 per cent of Chhattisgarh's tribal population resides here amid embarrassing poverty and endemic malaria; the lone sound of civilisation being an occasional airplane flying above. The Adivasis harvest small-sized rice *korsa* for six months and spend the remaining six selling it along with forest products. Tendu leaves are sold to local contractors at rates fixed by the Maoists. Despite living in the shadow of the gun, contractors get away by exploiting the Adivasis.

In the primitive economy of Abujmarh, the Left ultras have even designed small irrigational projects. Maoists are referred to as *dadas* by the tribes who carry out slash and burn cultivation. People's courts or *jan adalats* are justice delivery systems and Mao Zedong's red book is the sacred text. Revenue management is a serious part of the alternative establishment which propagates planned development through land sharing, cooperative farming and banking foodgrains and seeds. Abujmarh is *Janatana Sarkar*, the liberated place, which in Maoist parlance would be the model for replication across rural India. Seizure of urban India by encircling cities from the countryside remains their ultimate fantasy. Andhra Pradesh was the movement's pithead till five years back, but police operation there forced them to consolidate in Chhattisgarh.

At 14, Goodru has already enrolled into the Maoist's armed wing—the People's Liberation Guerrilla Army (PLGA). "I will soon be trained to handle a gun," he says in Gondi. Recruitment for PLGA begins early. A majority of Maoist armed cadres are between the age group of 14 to 25 years.

SECRET MISSION: Undisclosed venue of the congress

